

200BCE – 600CE

STYLE IN THE EAST

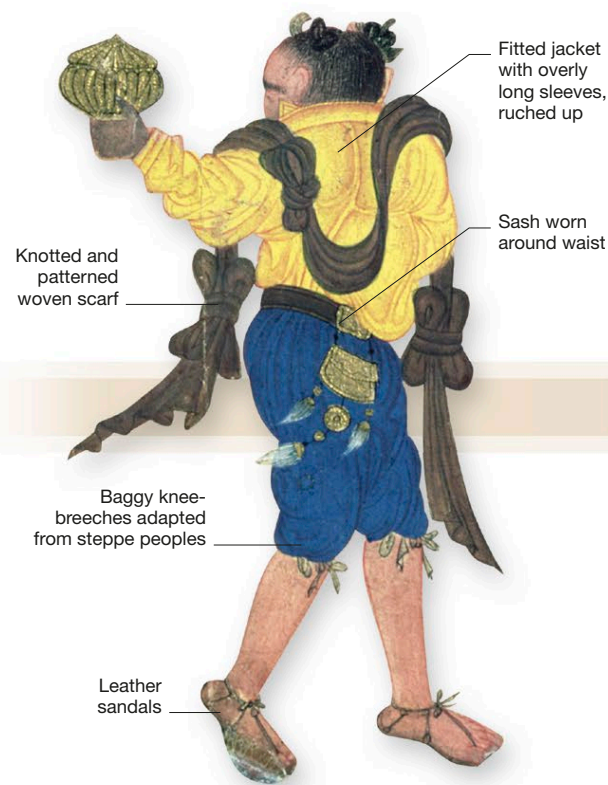
China was known as Ceres (from the word for silk) in the ancient world after its legendary and luxurious silks that were traded to the West along the Silk Road. The rich stashes of garments and accessories found in ancient tombs show how sophisticated the textiles and clothing were. They included highly patterned, light-reflective fabrics, and translucent gauze weaves. By layering garments of different lengths, and adding contrasting linings, waist sashes, and bands around the neck, strikingly colourful combinations were achieved. Elaborate cloth turbans and wide sleeves were to influence fashion in the West. The T-shaped kimono-style garments from China and Japan had wide sleeves that hung from the elbow over the wrist and different proportions from Western-style tunics. In central Asian and Persian areas (modern Iran and Iraq) clothing was more fitted, tight to the wrists and with shaped skirts, influenced by the nomadic, horse-riding peoples.



Servant girl The kneeling girl holding a functional oil lamp wears a simple robe that wraps around the body and is tied at the side. It has a distinct collar and cuffs. The lamp is from the Western Han dynasty (c.206BCE to 9th century CE).



Chinese scholar Xuanzang was a renowned Chinese Buddhist and scholar, depicted here returning from his pilgrimage to India. He is shown wearing a Chinese-style, wide-sleeved robe over loose breeches.



Chinese merchant On a piece of painted silk, this trader is portrayed as part of a group of merchants transporting their wares. His clothes are brightly coloured but practical: knee-breeches and a fitted jacket.



Yingpan Man This 4th–5th-century BCE masked Caucasoid mummy from the Tarim Basin, China, is dressed in a patterned silk coat and wraparound skirt. Discoveries like this along the Silk Road reveal the sophistication of silk weaving at the time.